

Candidate Questionnaire

Please limit each response to approximately 200 words.

Candidate Name: Uriah Ward

1. Vision for Technology in Education

What role should technology play in K-12 education, and how should that role differ across elementary, middle, and high school grade levels?

Technology is a tool that, I believe, can have positive impacts on student learning. But we cannot assume this is always the case. When research shows a traditional method produces better outcomes, we should use it. I am cognizant of the fiscal constraints we face amid continual budget cuts. There are times when the traditional method is more expensive, but if a lower-tech approach gets better results for kids, that cost may be worth it.

Technology's effects do seem to differ by grade level. Reading comprehension research finds paper outperforms screens, most clearly with younger readers (Clinton, 2019; Delgado et al., 2018), and research on screen exposure finds that younger children are more vulnerable to negative effects on language development than older children (Karani et al., 2022). I believe high schoolers benefit more from technology used for research, writing, and career preparation, and a peer-reviewed meta-analysis on reading instruction found greater learning gains for older students than younger ones (Cheung & Slavin, 2012).

There is also research suggesting that heightened technology use has negative social-emotional effects on young people. For all of these reasons, I authored the Board's new BIGG Goal on technology use in our district. We are evaluating the use of iPads in SPPS, including costs, cost savings, effects on instruction, and academic and social-emotional outcomes. I am eager to see the results of this research so we can begin using it to improve our schools for our students.

2. Student Devices and Classroom Learning

What is your perspective on the use of district-issued 1:1 devices (iPads) in Saint Paul Public Schools? What changes, if any, would you like to see in current practices (e.g., eliminate 1:1 devices for some or all grade levels, establish formal limits on screen time, move from iPads to Chromebooks, etc.)?

My answer to this question probably is not very satisfying. Our board has committed to studying this issue and I want to see the results of that research before making a determination about how to move forward.

I can say that I'm generally skeptical of tech solutions to problems in our education system. I believe that our field as a whole has rushed to adopt new technologies before acquiring evidence that these moves were best for students. I tend to trust the existing research that suggests we should use more traditional methods of instruction.

Every option is on the table, including the reduction or elimination of iPad use in our school district, limits on screen time, etc. I hope we can chart a path forward collaboratively, grounded in the evidence of what works best for our kids.

3. Attention, Engagement, and Student Well-Being

How should the district balance the educational benefits of technology with concerns related to student attention, engagement in learning, social development, mental health, and overall well-being?

Student attention, engagement, and well-being have to be part of how we evaluate technology in our schools, not an afterthought to academic outcomes. As I mentioned earlier, there is research suggesting that heightened technology use can have negative social-emotional effects on young people, and I take that concern seriously.

This is a central reason the Board committed to studying iPad use in SPPS through the BIGG Goal I authored. That evaluation specifically includes the social-emotional effects of technology on our students, alongside academic outcomes and cost. I don't think we can responsibly weigh the benefits of classroom technology without also weighing its effects on students' attention spans, social development, and mental health.

I want to see the results of that research before determining how the district should change course. I believe the district owes families a clear answer, grounded in evidence, about whether our current use of technology is serving our students' well-being or working against it.

4. Evidence and Learning Outcomes

What evidence or metrics would you want to see to determine whether classroom technology is improving student learning and educational outcomes and whether there is sufficient return on the district's investment?

I want a full range of evidence, just test scores. On the academic side, that includes standardized test scores, but also reading and math growth data broken down by grade level, so we can see whether the effects are different for younger and older students. On the financial side, I want clear cost-per-student numbers comparing our current technology investment to lower-tech alternatives, including the cost of device replacement, repair, and software licensing. As mentioned previously, I want to see data related to social-emotional wellbeing.

Data will not tell us everything we need to know. I want surveys of teachers, who see every day whether these tools help or get in the way of instruction. I want surveys of families, who see how technology use at school affects their kids at home. And I want surveys of students. Too often we make decisions about technology in schools without asking the students who actually use it. Students know how these devices affect their own attention and learning, and I want that included in this evaluation.

This is the kind of evidence our BIGG Goal calls for the district to gather before we decide whether our investment in iPads is working.

5. Family and Community Engagement

What role should parents, families, students, and educators play in shaping district technology policies and practices?

Families, students, and educators should be central to shaping how our district uses technology, not consulted after decisions are already made. This is why the BIGG Goal

builds in surveys of teachers, families, and students as part of our evaluation of iPad use in SPPS. Students in particular know how these devices affect their own attention and learning, and their voice belongs in this process.

I also want to recognize the parents, students, and community members who have already raised this concern directly to the Board. Groups like Intentional Technology Saint Paul have pushed us to take a harder look at how we use technology in our classrooms, and that advocacy is part of why this evaluation is happening. I want to keep hearing from them throughout this process, not just at the beginning.

Getting this right means genuine collaboration with the people closest to the classroom. I want families and students to help shape the questions we ask, weigh in as we gather evidence, and hold us accountable for following through on what we learn.

6. Accountability and Oversight

As a School Board member, how would you evaluate progress on technology-related goals and hold district leadership accountable for implementation, budget, and outcomes?

I will keep following up on this until we have real answers. At some point we will have an agenda item to hear the results of the BIGG Goal research. Depending on what we find, the Board may adopt a new goal that requires ongoing reporting at board meetings.

Beyond that, it is too early to say exactly which tools we will need, because we have not yet decided what direction to give the district. But I can tell you the tools available to us as a Board. We can attach directives to the budget once we know what we want to direct. We can require regular reporting from district leadership. We can build this into the Superintendent's evaluation. We could add it to the Superintendent's strategic plan. We can also stand up a subcommittee for more hands-on Board engagement if the issue warrants it.

Which of these we use will depend on what the research tells us and what changes, if any, are needed. But I want to be clear that studying this issue is not the end of the Board's involvement. It is the beginning of an accountability process that I intend to see through.

7. Artificial Intelligence

As artificial intelligence and other emerging technologies become increasingly available to students and educators, what principles should guide district decisions about their use? Do you support a moratorium on generative AI in Saint Paul Public Schools while the district undertakes a full review?

The same principles that guide my approach to other technology apply here: decisions should be evidence-based, cost-conscious, and centered on students' attention, learning, and well-being rather than convenience for adults.

As an adjunct professor, I saw students turn in poor work because they let AI do their thinking for them instead of doing it themselves. A growing body of research links heavy reliance on generative AI to weaker critical thinking and reduced cognitive effort, sometimes called cognitive offloading (Zhai et al., 2024). Students need to learn how to think, evaluate, and create for themselves, not outsource that work to a chatbot.

I have not called for a moratorium on generative AI in SPPS, but I am open to that conversation. If community members want to make that case, I would welcome a meeting to discuss it directly.

This is also why I helped write the Board's new AI Governance Goal, which commits the district to adopting an AI Governance Policy by the end of the 2027–28 school year.

8. Looking Ahead

If elected, what would be your highest priority related to technology use in Saint Paul Public Schools during your first term?

If elected, this would be my second term. My highest priority is follow-through. The Board adopted goals on iPad use and AI governance. Adopting a goal means nothing if we don't act on what we learn from it. My priority is making sure the district does the difficult, good-faith work to study these issues and then makes real changes based on the results, instead of letting the research sit on a shelf.

That means holding ourselves accountable to the timelines we've set. It means being honest with families about what the evidence shows. And it means being willing to change course when the evidence points that way, even when that's harder than keeping things as they are. Saint Paul families deserve a district that treats these questions seriously, not one that studies a problem and then moves on without acting on what it found.

References

Cheung, A. C. K., & Slavin, R. E. (2012). How features of educational technology applications affect student reading outcomes: A meta-analysis. *Educational Research Review*, 7(3), 198–215.

Clinton, V. (2019). Reading from paper compared to screens: A systematic review and meta-analysis. *Journal of Research in Reading*.

Delgado, P., Vargas, C., Ackerman, R., & Salmerón, L. (2018). Don't throw away your printed books: A meta-analysis on the effects of reading media on reading comprehension. *Educational Research Review*, 25, 23–38.

Karani, N. F., Sher, J., & Mophosho, M. (2022). The influence of screen time on children's language development: A scoping review. *South African Journal of Communication Disorders*, 69(1).

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Thank you for your participation. Please return to intentionaltechnologysaintpaul@gmail.com by September 25, 2026.